

The Philly Voucher Navigation Guide

You beat odds most people can't imagine just getting a Housing Choice Voucher. The cruel joke is that USING it is a second fight — deadlines, paperwork, landlords who ghost when they hear “Section 8.” This guide is the playbook for winning that second fight in Philadelphia.

The Timeline — Know It Cold

Stage	What happens	Your job
Briefing	PHA issues your voucher + packet	Read everything; note your EXACT expiration date
Search window	Typically 60–120 days to find a unit	Treat it like a job — daily searching from day 1
Landlord screening	Normal application process	Use the full Approval Package — vouchers don't skip screening
RFTA	Landlord + you submit Request for Tenancy Approval to PHA	Drive this — assemble it the same week they say yes
HQS inspection	PHA inspects the unit (often 4–6 weeks total)	Keep the landlord warm and informed
Lease + HAP	Lease signed, PHA contract executed	Confirm your portion in writing before signing

THE #1 VOUCHER MISTAKE

Treating the search window casually. Time pressure is your real enemy: every week spent on landlords who were never going to say yes is a week off your clock. If your voucher is close to expiring, request an extension from PHA in writing BEFORE it lapses — don't assume one.

Where Voucher Holders Actually Win

Big property management companies have formal, slow processes. Your best odds are **private landlords** — and your pitch to them is genuinely strong if you lead with the business case:

- **Guaranteed money:** the voucher portion arrives from PHA every month, recession-proof, job-loss-proof
- **Long tenancies:** voucher holders move far less often — less vacancy, less turnover cost
- **You're organized:** you arrive with documents ready (most applicants don't), which signals everything

Script (also in the Outreach Scripts doc): “My voucher pays \$X directly to you every month from PHA; my portion is \$Y, supported by [income]. I can start paperwork today and my documents are ready.”

Handling the RFTA Like a Pro

The RFTA (Request for Tenancy Approval) is where deals die of slowness. The landlord fills out most of it, but YOU should be the engine:

1. The day a landlord says yes, get the RFTA forms moving — same week, not next month
2. Help them complete it: rent amount, unit details, utilities responsibility. Errors = rejections = weeks lost
3. Confirm it was actually delivered to PHA's HCV office, and get a copy
4. Then keep the landlord engaged weekly during inspection scheduling — silence is how they drift to another applicant

Surviving the HQS Inspection

PHA inspects before approving the unit (Housing Quality Standards). Common first-visit failures are cheap fixes — flag them to the landlord BEFORE the inspector comes:

- Missing/dead smoke detectors (one per floor + outside bedrooms)
- Chipping paint — biggest issue in older Philly rowhomes, especially pre-1978
- Broken window locks, missing outlet covers, handrails on stairs
- Hot water temperature, working heat in every room

Framing this for the landlord: "Here's the inspection checklist — most failures are \$50 fixes. If we knock these out first, you pass first visit and the rent starts weeks sooner." You become the easiest deal on their desk.

Your Rights in Philadelphia

- **Source-of-income discrimination is ILLEGAL here.** "No Section 8" in a listing, or a sudden "it's rented" after you mention the voucher — both unlawful
- Save screenshots, texts, and listing copies. Report to the Philadelphia Commission on Human Relations (phila.gov/phr)
- The Renters' Access Act still protects you too: written screening criteria before fees, no auto-denials, appeal rights
- Free legal help: Community Legal Services (clsphila.org) and phillytenant.org

Key PHA Contacts

- HCV inspections: 215-684-2285 / hcvinspections@pha.phila.gov
- Landlord questions (give this to YOUR landlord): PHA Owner Services 215-684-5596 / hcvlandlords@pha.phila.gov
- Voucher-friendly listings: pha.phila.gov and affordablehousing.com

THE MINDSET

Every form you fill out fast, every inspection item you flag early, every weekly update you send — that's you converting a skeptical landlord into one who tells other landlords that voucher tenants are the easy ones. You're not asking for a favor. You're the most reliable rent check in Philadelphia.